

Research Notes

The thinking and the receipts behind the plan

Prepared for Mark Strazisar

Mark, this file shows you the thinking behind the plan. You do not need to read it to get started. It is here so you can see that every number and every claim in this packet stands on something real. Read the Start Here playbook, document 3, first. Come back here only if you want the receipts.

Date of research: May 2026.

1. About you, in your own track record

I studied your public site at markstraz.com, your resume page, and your public LinkedIn. Your personal site blocks automated readers, so I pulled your verified history from public search results that quote your resume and profile directly. Here is what the public record shows about you.

- More than 25 years in hospitality. Your own words on your profile describe more than 25 years of success building high value entertainment experiences with proven guest satisfaction.
- You have personally established and operated around 15 new concepts and venues. These generated record setting, multimillion dollar revenue. That is the single most important fact in this whole packet.
- Your concepts span the full range: restaurants, bars, lounges, dance bars, nightclubs, a coffee shop, and a family fun center.
- Roles you have held: Owner, Chief Operating Officer, and Vice President of Operations.
- Co-Owner and VP of Operations at OLIVEUS LLC, roughly 1992 to 2007, where you created many of those concepts.
- Owner of Straz Entertainment Group from about 2007, leading strategy, negotiations, and project management.
- Chief Operating Officer at an immersive Las Vegas concept (Cannabition) from about 2017 to 2019.
- Named wins that show up publicly:
- You helped take Beta Nightclub in Denver to the number one nightclub ranking in North America.
- You doubled sales at SUTRA Lounge and Left on Lincoln and earned a "best comeback lounge" recognition.
- You are described as someone who finds the root cause of guest complaints, team conflict, and facility problems, then fixes the system so it does not happen again.
- You have written employee training manuals and safety procedures, built hiring and onboarding programs, run profit and loss statements, and mentored general managers.
- Tools you already know: Aloha, Revel, Square, QuickBooks, and Excel.
- You live in Denver.
- You currently work for a large Denver restaurant group in a general manager or near general manager role.

Assumption noted: public search also surfaces a "Senior Mortgage Advisor" listing under a similar name. I treated that as either a different person or an old side note, and I built this packet around your hospitality career and your current restaurant group role, which is what the mission described and what your own site emphasizes. If any detail here is slightly off, it is easy to correct, and none of the plan depends on the exact dates.

Why this matters for the business: you are not learning to do a new thing. You already built the exact thing you are about to sell. Training manuals, safety procedures, onboarding programs, and the systems that let a concept open and run. You did it as an owner and operator, under real pressure, with real money on the line. The only new part is that a tool now helps you write it down faster.

2. About The Culinary Creative Group, your first and best customer

I studied their public pages and recent press. Here is the current picture.

- Founded in 2010 when Juan Padro and partners opened their first restaurant, Highland Tap and Burger, in Denver's Lower Highland neighborhood.
- Grown to around 23 restaurants, bars, and coffee shops. Public sources range from 21 to 23 as they keep opening and adjusting. Safe to say "more than 20 and still growing."
- Mostly Denver, plus Aspen, Colorado and New Orleans, Louisiana.
- Strong recognition. A5 Steakhouse, Ash'Kara, and Mister Oso have collectively earned six Michelin awards, including Bib Gourmand honors. Sap Sua has drawn James Beard attention.
- Named concepts that appear publicly: Highland Tap and Burger, the wider Tap and Burger concept across multiple locations, Bar Dough, A5 Steakhouse, Ash'Kara, Kumoya, Mister Oso (RiNo, Wash Park, Boulder, Denver airport, New Orleans), Aviano Coffee, Ay Papi, Bar Amorina, Forget Me Not, Fox and the Hen, Magna Kainan, Senor Bear, Sorry Gorgeous, and Sap Sua.
- They run their own consulting practice. Public description covers concept development and design, menu development, building front of house and back of house systems, real estate and lease negotiation, and large scale event management.

Leadership, current as of early 2026. This is important and it is good news for you.

- Richard Flaherty was named Chief Executive Officer in March 2026. He spent close to a year working alongside Juan Padro first. He previously led Punch Bowl Social and Wagamama in the United States.
- Juan Padro, the co-founder, is now an equity holder and strategic advisor. He is focused on investor relations, community, and social impact.
- Lauren Barash was named the group's first Vice President of Marketing.

- They already have a Director of Human Resources and a recruiting manager.

Note on the CFO: the mission mentioned a CFO named Katie O'Shea. I could not confirm that name in public sources during this research, so I left specific finance names out of your pitch. It does not affect the pitch, because you are not pitching the finance office. If you know the current finance leader's name from inside the company, you can add it.

Why the leadership change helps you: your new CEO comes from Punch Bowl Social and Wagamama. Those are brands built on repeatable systems, documented standards, and openings that run the same way every time. A leader from that world already believes in the value of written operating playbooks. You will not have to sell him on why systems matter. You only have to show him you can build them for these concepts, fast, from the inside.

3. The operational pain a growing group almost certainly has

This is not a guess about one company. It is what happens to every group that keeps opening locations. The public picture of this group fits the pattern exactly.

- Inconsistent training across locations. A server at one spot learns one way. A server at another learns a different way. The brand feels different depending on where you walk in.
- Knowledge lives in people's heads. The best general managers and bartenders carry the real playbook in their memory. When they leave, it leaves with them.
- Every opening starts close to scratch. A 23 unit group that keeps opening new spots often rebuilds training, checklists, and procedures each time instead of pulling a proven playbook off the shelf.

Your lane sits exactly on this pain. You make the knowledge in people's heads into documents anyone can use. You make every opening start from a proven playbook instead of a blank page. That is floor level operations work. It is not human resources compliance, and it is not recruiting. That distinction is the heart of how you stay in your lane and complement their existing HR team, which is covered in the pitch section of the Start Here playbook.

4. What good looks like, from groups that already scaled

I looked at how respected multi unit groups standardize. These are the models to point to.

- Lettuce Entertain You, the largest privately held restaurant group in the country, has run a structured training program for more than fifty years. Training is not left to chance. It is a system.

- Union Square Hospitality Group, founded by Danny Meyer, built detailed operating playbooks. One public example was a 36 page playbook covering training, menus, and safety for reopening. They also run a consulting and professional development arm.
- Across strong groups, the common thread is the same. Consistent, repeatable procedures. Clear written systems. Shared standards. An operations function whose job is to keep the brand and the culture identical from location to location.

The takeaway for your pitch: the best groups in the country treat written systems as a competitive advantage, not paperwork. You are offering this group the same advantage, built by someone who already knows their floors.

5. Real pricing, so every number in the packet is defensible

I researched what restaurant operations consultants, fractional operations leaders, and procedure and training builders actually charge in 2026. Ranges below come from current public consulting and restaurant industry sources.

- Hourly: restaurant consultants commonly charge 100 to 500 dollars per hour.
- Monthly retainers: small ongoing engagements run about 1,500 to 5,000 dollars per month. Fractional operations executives, who work 5 to 15 hours a week for six months or more, run about 5,000 to 15,000 dollars per month.
- Projects: project fees commonly run 5,000 to 50,000 dollars depending on scope.
- Building a set of procedures by hand takes time. A focused set of standard operating procedures can take 15 to 20 hours of work, more for a full system.

How I turned that into your prices. Your model is different from an on site fractional executive. You work from home, at your own pace, producing finished documents. So I anchored your build retainer below the fractional executive range and above the small retainer range, which fits a serious build done remotely. I set per document prices in line with focused procedure work. I set the full project price below what an outside firm would charge a 23 unit group to build the whole system from the outside, which would realistically run 30,000 to 75,000 dollars or more once you add travel and discovery time. Your advantage is that you already know their floors, so your discovery time is near zero. Every number in the Start Here playbook sits inside these researched ranges.

6. Sources

- Mark Strazisar public profile and resume references: markstraz.com and public LinkedIn search results.

- The Culinary Creative Group: theculinarycreative.com (our company, consulting services, restaurants), plus FSR Magazine and BusinessDen coverage of the March 2026 CEO transition, and 5280 and Colorado Sun coverage of concepts and awards.
- Pricing: current public consulting and restaurant industry pricing guides covering hourly rates, monthly retainers, and project fees for restaurant and operations consulting in 2026.
- Standardization models: public coverage of Lettuce Entertain You and Union Square Hospitality Group operating and training programs.

All information used is public. Nothing here came from inside any company.